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CRIME EXPOSURE, PERCEIVED STATE PRESENCE, AND PSYCHOLOGICAL WELL-BEING AMONG YOUNG PEOPLE AGED 17-19 LIVING IN LOWER-HUMAN-DEVELOPMENT DISTRICTS OF METROPOLITAN LIMA

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Introduction

People's experiences in Metropolitan Lima can be very different depending on where they live. Some districts have better access to public services, education, health care, and other opportunities, while others face more limitations [8]. These differences can also be seen in levels of human development. In its 2025 Human Development Report, the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) found that important differences in human development and state presence still exist across Peru. Because the report includes information at the district level, it is possible to see these differences more clearly from one area to another [1].

Crime is another factor that can affect people's everyday environment. The National Institute of Statistics and Informatics (INEI) collects information about crime victimization and how insecure people feel in Metropolitan Lima. Its 2025 report also looks at how insecurity affects people's daily lives and the actions they take to protect themselves from crime [2]. This shows that crime is not only about the number of offenses that are reported; people's personal experiences and their perception of insecurity are also important when trying to understand how crime affects everyday life.

These issues are particularly relevant for young people. Previous research has suggested that the way people perceive the danger of crime may be connected to their psychological well-being. For example, a 2023 study of university students found a relationship between perceived danger from crime, coping strategies, and psychological distress, a connection that was stronger among students who had experienced crime themselves [3]. Research carried out in Lima has also found differences in perceptions of insecurity depending on socioeconomic conditions [4]. Other recent studies have looked at the connection between fear of crime and factors such as perceived risk, social well-being, life satisfaction, and psychological distress [5].

Even so, these studies do not necessarily look at all of these factors together among young people from different districts of Metropolitan Lima. Crime, insecurity, psychological well-being, and perceived state presence are distinct concepts, but they can be closely connected in people's everyday experiences. Studying them together may help provide a clearer picture of how young people perceive the environment in which they live.

For this reason, this study will focus on young people aged 17 to 19 who live in districts of Metropolitan Lima with lower levels of human development. This age group represents late adolescence, a critical developmental stage in which many life transitions occur at the same time. During these years, young people are developing their identity, making decisions about their education and future careers, and starting to think more seriously about their long-term trajectories [11]. The World Health Organization (WHO) describes this period as one in which young people face important psychosocial challenges as they formulate plans for their future [11]. Because of this, the social and environmental context around them can be particularly meaningful during these years.

The purpose of this research is not to assume that living in a certain district determines how a young person feels or how they will experience their life, as two individuals in the same neighborhood can have completely different experiences. Instead, this study will examine whether exposure to crime, perceived state presence, psychological well-being, and expectations about the future are connected. By paying close attention to how young people describe their own surroundings, this research aims to better understand not only the social conditions in which these young people live, but also how they make sense of those conditions and what they mean for their view of the future.

Research Questions

This study looks at how the environment where young people live may be connected to their everyday experiences, well-being, and ideas about the future. It will focus on young people between 17 and 19 years old who live in the three districts of Metropolitan Lima with the lowest levels of human development, according to the district-level Human Development Index reported by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in 2025. Through semi-structured interviews, the study will give young people the opportunity to talk about how they experience their surroundings, the public services available to them, their sense of safety, and the opportunities they see in their communities.

Central Research Question

How are exposure to crime, perceptions of the State's presence, and the conditions of the district where they live connected to the psychological well-being and future expectations of young people aged 17–19 in low-human-development districts of Metropolitan Lima?

Specific Research Questions

1. How do young people aged 17–19 feel that the environment around them affects their psychological well-being?
2. How do young people describe the presence of the State and the public services available in their districts?
3. How do their experiences with crime and their perceptions of safety influence the way they think about their future?
4. What similarities and differences emerge when comparing the experiences of young people from the three districts?

Literature Review

People do not experience a city in exactly the same way. Where a person lives can influence the services they can access, the opportunities available to them, and even how safe or supported they feel in everyday life. In Peru, these differences can be seen at the district level. In its 2025 Human Development Report, the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) uses the Human Development Index (HDI) to examine differences between territories in areas such as health, education, and income. The report shows that, despite progress in human development and state presence, significant differences between territories still remain [1]. Because of this, the district where a person lives can be an important part of understanding their social environment.

This is particularly relevant in Metropolitan Lima. Although Lima is often viewed as one large urban area, living conditions can be quite different from one district to another. A study based on Lima Cómo Vamos surveys conducted between 2010 and 2019 found that residents' satisfaction with different aspects of the city was generally unfavorable and became less positive over time. The study also found that people from lower socioeconomic groups tended to have less favorable perceptions of public services, safety, public spaces, and other aspects of urban life [4]. These findings suggest that the way people view their surroundings is partly related to the conditions they experience in their everyday lives.

Safety is another important part of this experience. Data from the National Institute of Statistics and Informatics (INEI) show that victimization and fear of becoming a victim of crime continue to be relevant issues in Peru and Metropolitan Lima [2]. However, feeling unsafe does not necessarily mean that someone has personally experienced a crime. Research on fear of crime suggests that these perceptions can also be influenced by what people hear about crime, what

they see in their neighborhoods, and how safe they feel in the places they visit regularly [5]. For young people, these perceptions may affect everyday decisions, such as where they go, how they move around their communities, and how they interact with the people around them.

The relationship between perceived danger and psychological well-being has also been explored in previous research. Altamirano, Melo-Moreno, and Garcia studied university students and found a relationship between perceived danger, coping strategies, and mental health [3]. Their participants were university students rather than the 17–19-year-old population examined in the present study, so their findings cannot be directly applied to this age group. Still, their research is useful because it shows that the way people perceive their environment can be related to their psychological well-being. Other research on adolescent health has also emphasized that young people's well-being is influenced by the social and economic conditions in which they grow up [6][7][9].

Public institutions are another part of this environment. A district is more than just a geographic area; it is also where people interact with schools, health services, transportation systems, local government, public spaces, and other institutions. When these services are difficult to access or do not meet people's expectations, this may affect how residents see their community and the opportunities they believe they have. UNICEF has also emphasized the importance of taking adolescents' needs and experiences into account when addressing access to health and mental health services in Peru [10]. This becomes especially relevant during late adolescence, when young people begin making decisions about education, work, independence, and their future.

These issues are particularly relevant to Pucusana, Pachacámac, and Ancón, the three districts selected for this study based on district-level human development information from the UNDP [1]. Examining these districts separately is useful because treating Metropolitan Lima as a single space can make local differences less visible. Previous research provides important information about human development, public services, insecurity, and well-being in Peru and Lima, but much of this work is based on surveys, statistical indicators, or broad population groups [1][2][4][5]. These sources help describe the larger context, but they do not necessarily show how young people themselves understand the places where they live.

For this reason, it is useful to look more closely at the experiences of young people in these three districts and becomes crucial during late adolescence (ages 17–19), a period defined by identity formation, growing autonomy, and key transitions regarding higher education, employment, and future life projects [11]. What they expect from their future may be influenced by the opportunities they see around them, but also by how safe, supported, and connected they feel in their communities. The present study therefore uses semi-structured interviews to explore how young people in Pucusana, Pachacámac, and Ancón describe their local environment, their experiences with safety and public services, their psychological well-being, and the way these experiences may shape how they think about their future.

Rather than assuming that living in a district with a lower level of human development automatically results in negative experiences, this study gives young people the opportunity to explain their realities in their own words. Their perspectives may reveal aspects of everyday life that are not visible in district-level indicators alone. In this way, the study seeks to provide a more personal understanding of how territorial conditions are experienced by young people living in different parts of Metropolitan Lima.

Proposed Methodology - Research Design and Approach

This study will use a qualitative approach to understand how young people experience and make sense of the environment around them. More specifically, it will follow a phenomenological design, since the main interest is in their personal experiences and in the meaning they give to what happens in their communities. This approach is useful because the study is not only interested in whether young people feel safe or unsafe, but also in understanding why they feel that way and how they connect these experiences with their well-being and their plans for the future.

Participants and Sampling

The study will include between 18 and 24 young people aged 17–19. There will be approximately 6 to 8 participants from each of the three districts included in the study: Pucusana, Pachacámac, and Ancón. These districts were selected because they have the lowest Human Development Index (HDI) levels in Metropolitan Lima according to the UNDP [1].

Participants will be selected through purposive sampling, meaning that the study will look for young people who fit the characteristics needed for the research. Snowball sampling will also be used, allowing participants to recommend other young people who may be interested in taking part. This can help reach participants with different experiences and perspectives within each district.

Data Collection

16 The information will be collected through individual semi-structured interviews. Each interview will last approximately 45 to 60 minutes. The questions will be organized around four main topics: how young people experience safety and crime in their neighborhoods, how they view public services and the presence of the State, how they describe their own psychological well-being, and how they think about their future in terms of education and employment.

The interviews will not be limited to fixed questions. Depending on what each participant shares, additional questions will be asked to give them the opportunity to explain their

6 experiences in greater detail. This will allow the conversations to remain focused on the research topic while still leaving room for participants to bring up experiences or ideas that may be important to them.

Data Analysis

With the participants' permission, the interviews will be audio-recorded and then transcribed word for word. The transcripts will be analyzed using Reflexive Thematic Analysis [12]. The analysis will begin with becoming familiar with the interviews and identifying ideas that appear repeatedly or seem particularly relevant. These ideas will then be organized into initial codes and possible themes. The themes will be reviewed and refined before being clearly defined and named. Finally, the findings will be brought together in the final report.

After analyzing the interviews, the study will also compare the experiences of participants from Pucusana, Pachacámac, and Ancón. The purpose of this comparison will be to identify experiences that are shared across the three districts as well as differences that may help explain how young people experience their local environments in different ways.

Ethical Considerations

Because the study involves young people and asks about experiences that may be personal or sensitive, particular attention will be given to ethical considerations. Participants who are 18 or 19 years old will provide informed consent before taking part. For participants who are 17, written consent from a parent or legal guardian will be obtained, along with the participant's own assent.

Taking part in the study will be completely voluntary. Participants will be informed that they can choose not to answer a question or stop participating if they no longer wish to continue. Their privacy will also be protected. Names and other identifying information will not be included in the research report; instead, pseudonyms will be used so that individual participants cannot be identified.

Expected Outcomes

This study is expected to help explain how young people between the ages of 17 and 19 experience the places where they live. Through their own stories, the research may identify common ideas about safety, crime, public services, the presence of the State, psychological well-being, and their expectations for the future. At the same time, it may show that young people from Pucusana, Pachacámac, and Ancón do not necessarily experience their communities in the same way. The study is not intended to produce results that can be applied to every young person in these districts. With a small number of participants, its main value will be in understanding their experiences in more detail. Listening directly to young people can provide information that is difficult to see in statistics alone, especially when it comes to how they feel about their surroundings and how these experiences may influence the way they think about their future.

Potential Limitations

This study also has some limitations. The first is the number of participants. Since only 18 to 24 young people will be interviewed across the three districts, their experiences cannot represent all young people living in Pucusana, Pachacámac, or Ancón. However, having a smaller group makes it possible to spend more time listening to each participant and understanding their experiences in greater depth. Another limitation is that the information will come directly from what participants remember and decide to share. When talking about experiences with crime, safety, or psychological well-being, some participants may feel uncomfortable discussing certain situations or may leave out details. Their answers may also be influenced by how they feel during the interview or by what they believe is acceptable to say. It may also be more difficult to find participants in some districts than in others. This could affect the variety of experiences included in the study. To deal with these limitations as carefully as possible, the interviews will be analyzed following the same general process, while the researcher will also reflect on their own role in interpreting what participants say.

Conclusion

This study aims to understand territorial inequality in Metropolitan Lima by looking at it from the perspective of young people who live in these environments every day. By focusing on Pucusana, Pachacámac, and Ancón, the research gives young people an opportunity to describe their communities in their own words and to explain how they experience the conditions around them. The study does not assume that living in a district with a lower level of human development automatically determines a young person's well-being or future. Two people can live in the same district and have very different experiences depending on their families, relationships, opportunities, and personal circumstances. Because of this, the research will focus on how young people understand their surroundings and how they believe these experiences are connected to their well-being and plans for the future. By combining these personal experiences with existing information about human development, crime, public services, and living conditions, the study can offer a fuller picture of what life is like for young people in different parts of Metropolitan Lima. Most importantly, it gives space to their own experiences instead of reducing them to numbers or statistics.

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